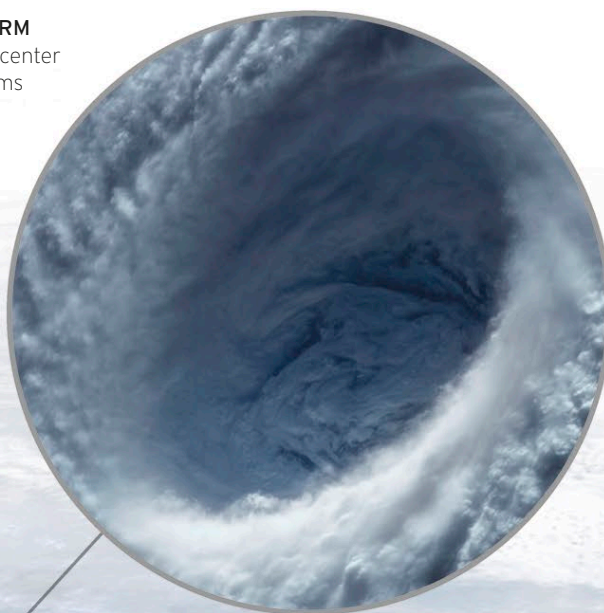


▷ THE EYE OF THE STORM

Air in the relatively calm center of a tropical cyclone warms as it descends, leaving it clear of cloud. It is possible to see blue sky from the ocean surface as the eye passes.

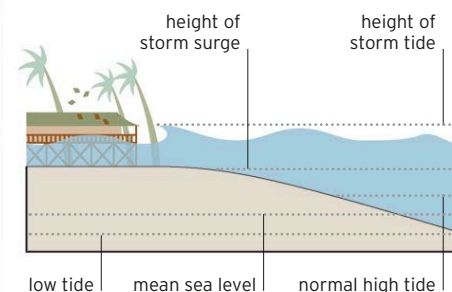


Cold exhaust

Cooled air at high altitudes spirals away from the eye or descends into it.

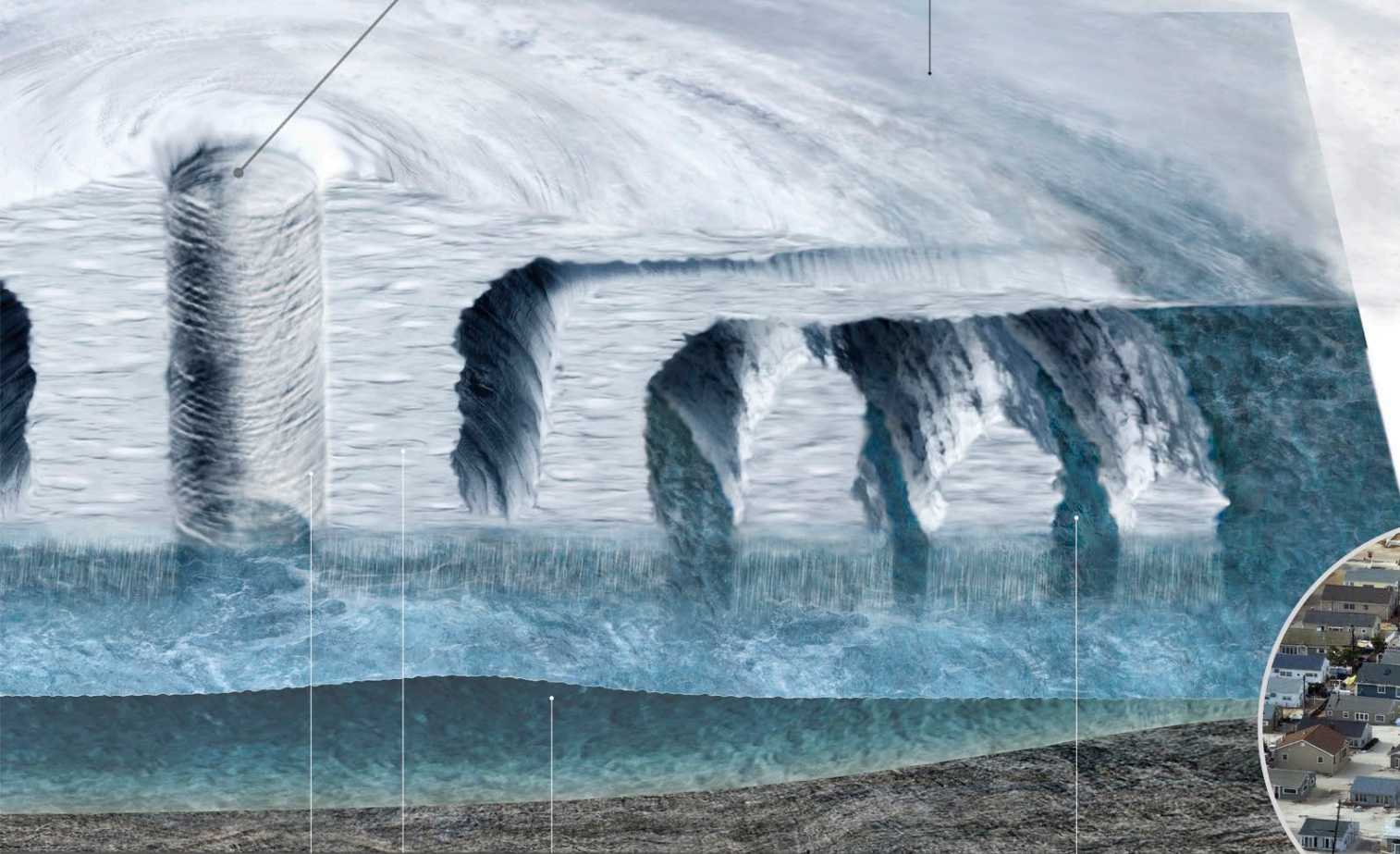
STORM SURGES

Hurricane-force winds blowing onshore bunch ocean water up to abnormal levels in shallow coastal waters. This creates a storm surge—an abnormal rise of water that is higher than the predicted astronomical tides. When combined with normal high tide, this creates a storm tide and can cause extreme flooding in coastal areas.



Cirrus shield

Cooled air fans out into high-altitude cirrus cloud, spreading 620 miles (1,000 km) or more.



Eye

In the eye, typically 20–40 miles (30–65 km) across, air warms as it descends. The winds are lighter than anywhere else in the storm, but the ocean beneath the eye is rough.

Eyewall

The fastest winds are in the eyewall.

Storm surge

As the storm reaches the coast, a storm surge occurs where winds are blowing onshore.

Moat

Clear rings between concentric cloudbands are where cooled air is slowly sinking.



△ STORM STRUCK

Around 250,000 vehicles were destroyed, mainly by flooding caused by the storm surge, when Hurricane Sandy made landfall on the eastern seaboard of the U.S. in 2012.